

THAT DEEPER FEELING

Growing the Spine

That Was Never Allowed to Form

A Three-Day Immersive Retreat
for Women

[Dates • Location]

Facilitated by Kimberly Bryant

DAY ONE — ARRIVING

“Coming home to yourself before anything else is asked of you”

3:00 PM — Arrival & Sacred Space

[45 minutes]

Women arrive and settle. No agenda yet. Tea, water, something warm. Soft music. The space itself doing its first work — signaling: this is different from ordinary life.

Facilitator present but not facilitating. Just human. The conversations before the official beginning are often where the deepest first connections form.

Room setup: Circular seating. No tables between people. Candles. Botanicals. Warm low light. The SPINE illustration visible but not explained yet — something to be curious about.

3:45 PM — The Opening Circle

[60 minutes]

“Before we do anything else — just arrive. Feel your body in the chair. Your feet on the floor. You made it here. Whatever it took to get here — notice that you did it.”

Two minutes of silence. Then the check-in: each woman shares one word for what she’s carrying in, one word for what she’s hoping for. No commentary from the group. Just receiving, around the circle.

Then Kimberly: the framework introduction. Not a lecture. A story. The story of what the exoskeleton replaced. Fifteen minutes. Warm and specific — naming experiences the women in the room have likely had, in language that produces recognition rather than information.

Watch for: the small intake of breath, the eyes filling, the laugh of recognition. Those are the first unauthorized feelings arriving. Name them, gently: “Something is landing for some of you. Let it.”

5:00 PM — The Embodied Vision Self

[75 minutes]

Guided visualization — the most important practice of Day One.

Lights lower. Soft music. Women lying down or in whatever position their body wants. Ten minutes of progressive arrival — breath, body contact, ground.

Then the visualization: the free version of herself. Not perfect. Not performing wellness. Just free. What does she look like? How does she move? What does her intimate life feel like? Her emotional life? How does she stand in her own authority?

Twenty minutes for the visualization. Silence after.

Then: journaling. Fifteen minutes. The question: Who did you find?

Then: small groups of three. Each woman shares — if she chooses — one thing she found. The group witnesses without comment, without advice, without “me too” in that moment. Just receives.

This visualization sometimes surfaces grief rather than vision. The free self feels impossibly distant rather than imaginable. If this happens for someone — let it. The grief is the first unauthorized feeling. It belongs here.

6:30 PM — Dinner Together

[90 minutes]

Shared meal. No agenda. Facilitator present and human — not leading, not processing, just being. The table is its own kind of practice.

8:00 PM — The Spider Map Introduction

[60 minutes]

Introduction to the SPINE framework — the five domains. Not through a lecture. Through questions.

Sovereignty: “When was the last time you had a thought or feeling and just — let it be yours, before you evaluated whether you were allowed to have it?”

Power: “When did you last give yourself permission for something without waiting for someone else to grant it?”

Identity: “Who shows up when no one is watching and no one is telling you who you should be?”

Nourishment: “What have you been calling sin that might have been food?”

Embodiment: “When did you last feel genuinely at home in your body?”

No answers required. Just sitting with the questions. Journal time after each one. Brief introduction to the spider chart concept — not scores yet, just the visual metaphor of the two shapes and the gap between them.

9:00 PM — Evening Practice & Close

[30 minutes]

The first Daily Return practice — done together, in the room. “Before you sleep tonight — find your hands. Let them land on your body without deciding where first. Stay for sixty seconds. One breath longer going out. And then: I live here.”

Practice together in the room first. Then close the day with a brief ceremony. Candle lighting — each woman lights one. The room holds their lights together for a moment before they take them to their rooms.

DAY TWO — THE RECLAMATION

“Sovereignty, Power, and the things that were starved”

7:30 AM — Morning Movement

[45 minutes]

No words. Music. Bodies moving however they want to move. The explicit instruction: “There is no right way to do this. You cannot do this wrong.”

Many women from these systems have never moved their bodies for their own pleasure. This is the first practice of Day Two — the body expressing itself before the day asks anything of it. Kimberly moving in the room, not demonstrating a right way but modeling freedom. If someone freezes — a gentle hand on the shoulder, a quiet “your body knows” if needed.

8:30 AM — Breakfast

[60 minutes]

9:30 AM — The Assessment

[90 minutes]

The full SPINE Self-Map — completed individually, in silence. Soft music. Women working through the inventory at their own pace.

Facilitator available but not hovering. Tissues available. Permission to stop if something becomes too much.

After completion: each woman draws her rough shape — the meta spider chart by hand in her journal. Not precise. Just the approximate shape of where she is.

Partner share (pairs): “What does your shape show you that you already knew? What surprises you?”

11:00 AM — Sovereignty Work

[90 minutes]

Teaching: Interior Ownership — the specific way the system claimed your inner life, and what it looks like to begin taking it back. Twenty minutes. Stories and recognition.

Activity — The Interior Inventory:

Three things in my interior that feel genuinely mine. Three things I'm still not sure about. Three things I've been told belong to God, the community, my spouse, the doctrine — that I want to look at. Not to resolve. Just to look.

Activity — The Shame Source Circle:

Facilitator reads each shame source slowly, with space. Women silently rate their own response. Then: "Without saying what it is — raise your hand if any of these scored 4 or 5."

Nearly every hand goes up.

"Look around the room."

That moment — without anyone speaking a specific shame aloud — is often the most powerful of the retreat.

12:30 PM — Lunch

[75 minutes]

2:00 PM — Power and Voice

[90 minutes]

Teaching: Self-Authorization and Voice Activation — the specific targeting of your voice by the system, and what it looks like to begin speaking from your own center. Twenty minutes.

Activity — The Small Yes:

Each woman identifies one thing she's been waiting for permission to do. Writes it. Then says it aloud to one other person: "I give myself permission to ____."

*The witnessing of another woman giving herself permission — and being witnessed doing so — is itself healing.
Watch for it landing in the room.*

Activity — The Voice Practice (pairs):

One woman speaks, one witnesses. Speaking woman completes three sentences:

“Something I’ve never said out loud about what I want is ____.”

“Something I’ve been afraid to say in an intimate context is ____.”

“Something I’m giving myself permission to say from now on is ____.”

Witness’s only role: be fully present. No advice. No “me too” in this moment. Just receive. Then switch.

3:45 PM — Break

[30 minutes]

4:15 PM — Nourishment

[90 minutes]

Teaching: The Starvation Story. What the system said about your desire. What the hunger actually is. What you’ve been calling sin that was actually food. Kimberly’s own story, appropriately and selectively shared, is the most powerful vehicle for this teaching.

Activity — The Want List:

Private writing. Everything you’ve ever wanted, been curious about, been drawn to — that the system said was wrong or dangerous. Not to act on. Just to see.

“If you want to burn this list after, that’s yours to choose. But first — make it. See it. Let yourself see what’s actually there.”

Activity — What Was Starved (small groups of three):

Each person shares — if they choose — one thing that was starved in them. The group witnesses without evaluation, advice, or silver lining.

Facilitator models: "I receive that." The group follows. This is where both irreducible moments occur simultaneously: unauthorized feeling in the speaking, non-evaluative witnessing in the receiving.

6:00 PM — Free Time / Rest

[90 minutes]

7:30 PM — The Sensory Feast

[60 minutes]

Stations of pure sensory pleasure — taste, texture, sound, scent, warmth. Women move through at their own pace.

"Your only job is to notice what you notice. Stay as long as something is interesting. Leave when it's done."

No discussion during. Journaling after.

8:30 PM — Evening Ceremony

[45 minutes]

The want lists from the afternoon — held, offered, burned (if chosen). Each woman chooses what to do with hers.

Then: candle circle. Each woman speaks one sentence aloud: "I am allowed to ____."

Full circle. Witnessed by all. The room holds the collection of permissions together for a moment before closing.

DAY THREE — THE BODY IS THE HOME

“Embodiment, integration, and the spine that is growing”

7:30 AM — The Embodied Morning

[60 minutes]

Gentle yoga or somatic movement — not about achievement, about arrival. A guide who understands this population (no performance cues, no “push yourself,” only invitation).

Or, if no movement guide: thirty minutes of the Daily Return practice done together, followed by thirty minutes of free movement to music.

9:00 AM — Breakfast

[60 minutes]

10:00 AM — Embodiment Work

[90 minutes]

Teaching: The Body as Home. How the system located authority in the spirit and made the body a site of danger and management. What re-embodiment actually looks like — not transcendence of the body, but return to it. Twenty minutes.

Activity — Body Gratitude (Revisioned):

Not “thank your body for what it does for you.” Instead: “Thank your body for what it survived. For what it held. For the desire it kept alive when you were trying to suppress it. For the no it knew before you let yourself know it. For waiting.”

Written, then spoken aloud — to their own body, privately, hands on the relevant part.

Activity — Felt Sense Introduction:

Brief introduction to the felt sense (Gendlin's Focusing, simplified). One question: "Is there somewhere in your body right now that has something to say about this weekend?"

Let the body speak in whatever language it chooses — sensation, image, impulse, emotion. Just receive it.

11:30 AM — Integration Work

[90 minutes]

Activity — The SPINE Portrait:

Each woman draws her own SPINE — five vertebrae, labeled, decorated according to where she is in each domain. Not for assessment. For claiming. This goes home with her.

Activity — The Practice Prescription (self-written):

Each woman identifies her top three practices. Writes them in her own words. Names why she's choosing these.

Small groups — The Commitment Share:

Each person shares her three practices. The group witnesses. No advice. "I hear that you're going to ____." The public naming is part of the commitment.

1:00 PM — Lunch & Transition

[90 minutes]

2:30 PM — The Closing Ceremony

[90 minutes]

Activity — Letters to the Free Self:

Each woman writes a letter to the version of herself she described in the Day One visualization. What do you want to tell her? What are you on the way to? What do you need her to know?

Sealed. Addressed to themselves. Kimberly mails them in three months.

The Final Circle:

Each woman completes one sentence: "I am taking one thing from this retreat that belongs to me now."

You came here with a spine that was prevented from forming. Not broken — prevented. There's a difference. Broken things need repair. Prevented things need permission.

Over three days you've looked at territory that the system fenced off, locked up, or set on fire. You've named what was starved. You've spoken what was silenced. You've let your body tell you something true.

The spine is growing. Not all at once. Not perfectly. But it's growing. And nobody gets to stop it now.

Take your practices home. Do them imperfectly. Skip days. Come back. The body is patient. It's been waiting for you to come home. It will wait a little longer if it needs to.

But you started. That's the part that can't be undone.

You are the evidence that leaving doesn't mean losing yourself. Go be evidence.

— Kimberly